

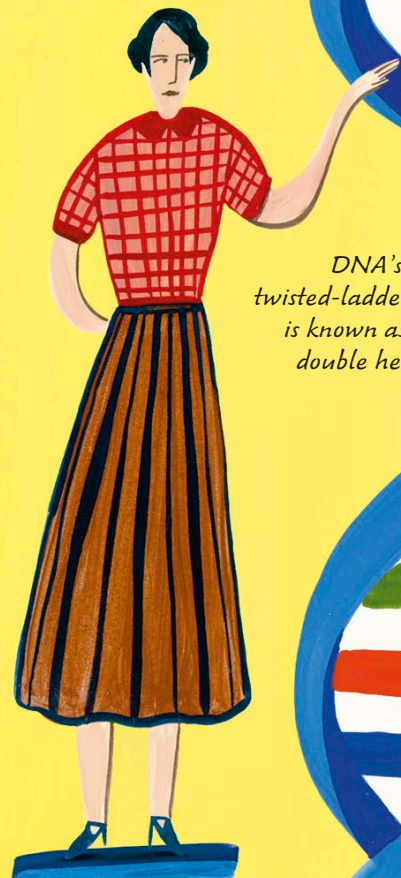


ROSALIND FRANKLIN

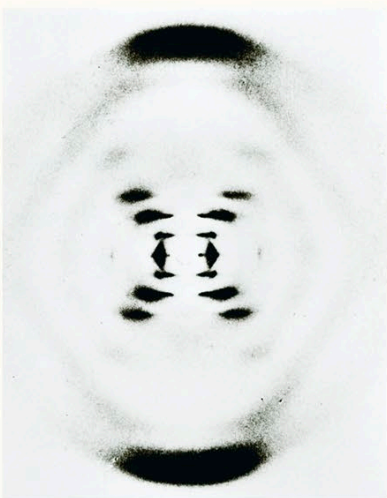
English chemist
1920–1958

In the mid-20th century, several teams of scientists were competing to understand a mysterious molecule called deoxyribonucleic acid (DNA). This is found in the cells of every living thing. The scientists knew that DNA carried the instructions for building living things, but no one knew how it worked!

Rosalind Franklin was an expert at taking photographs of tiny molecules and using these pictures to figure out what they were made from. In May 1952, she took her best photo yet, showing that DNA was shaped like a twisted ladder. Rosalind had found a key piece of the puzzle—one that other scientists would use to make the all-important discovery about the structure of DNA.



*DNA's
twisted-ladder shape
is known as the
double helix.*



X-ray crystallography

Rosalind didn't take her photographs using an ordinary camera. She did it by passing X-rays through crystals of a molecule and looking closely at the shadowy patterns they made. The patterns revealed how atoms are arranged inside the molecules.